that without abandoning his old religious intolerance that earned him those American strictures.

The problem is that the dominant strand in the ruling party cares far more about asserting Hindu chauvinism than it does about the economic reforms and investments that Mr Modi trumpeted—and which won him the support of voters who did not share his 'Hindutva' agenda. A party dependent on people who urge Hindu women to have four children —'no, ten!', as the Shankaracharya of Badrikashram said—not only shows profound disrespect to Hindu women[2] (who have to endure the labour to fulfil the Hindutva brigade's political fantasies) but proves itself out of touch with the real values and priorities of the Hindu masses in whose name it claims to speak.

The fact remains that the Modi regime has given free rein to the most retrograde elements in Indian society, who are busy rewriting textbooks to glorify Hindu leaders, extolling the virtues of ancient science over modern technology, beating the drums over 'love jihad', extolling *ghar wapsi*, and asserting that India's identity must be purely Hindu. Majoritarian communalism, as Nehru had long recognised, is a fundamental threat to our pluralist democracy. But throughout his life as an RSS *pracharak*, Modi has devoted himself to the very worldview that is undermining India's harmony.

## TOLERANCE AND ACCEPTANCE

As a believing Hindu, I cannot agree with the followers of Hindutva. Indeed, I am ashamed of what they are doing while claiming to be acting in the name of my faith. The violence is particularly sickening: it has led hundreds of thousands of Hindus across India to protest with placards screaming, 'Not In My Name'. As I have explained throughout this book, and would like to reiterate, I have always prided myself on belonging to a religion of astonishing breadth and range of belief; a religion that acknowledges all ways of worshipping God as equally valid —indeed, the only major religion in the world that does not claim to be the only true religion. As I have often asked: How dare a bunch of thugs shrink the soaring majesty of the Vedas and the *Upanishad*s to the petty bigotry of their brand of identity politics? Why should any Hindu allow